

Strategic Roadmap for Platform-Centric I&O

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Initiatives: Functional Design

Making the I&O organization effective in managing infrastructure platforms requires updating all aspects of its work. This research provides the actions and milestones that heads of I&O must implement to maximize the value their organization gets from platform investments.

More on This Topic

This is part of an in-depth collection of research. See the collection:

- [Blueprint for Platform-Centric I&O](#)

Overview

Key Findings

- Issues with infrastructure platform performance can often be traced to the head of I&O not addressing persistent gaps in managing infrastructure assets, operational workflows and I&O services that underpin them, requiring sustained attention and investments to do so.
- Successful platform adoption is far more likely if heads of I&O complement existing capabilities with additional capacities for managing platforms rather than the wholesale restructuring of all aspects of I&O people, processes and tools.
- Platform success requires heads of I&O to create cross-functional teams that collaborate effectively with other IT and business functions to address the various challenges that come with managing infrastructure platforms.

Recommendations

- Prepare for the effective oversight of infrastructure platforms by closing critical gaps in managing existing I&O systems along with implementing new policies, metrics and cost allocation models that are conducive to operating infrastructure platforms.
- Establish practices and tools vital to managing infrastructure platforms by investing in agile delivery models, platform management toolsets and observability platforms, supplemented with updated roles and responsibilities, sourcing methods and systems of record that account for infrastructure platform needs.
- Design systems and environments for infrastructure platform success by using an anchor and complement model for infrastructure platform development and creating distinct infrastructure platform team structures that have access to reconfigurable, flexible workspaces to carry out their work.

Strategic Planning Assumption

By 2028, 70% of I&O functions will be expected to operate as platform-centric, up from 25% in 2025.

Introduction

This strategic roadmap is part of the [Blueprint for Platform-Centric I&O](#), a collection of research that helps heads of I&O set up their organizations to manage the complexity of infrastructure platforms underpinning digital products. This strategic roadmap provides all heads of I&O with insight into how to address the performance gaps that will limit the value of infrastructure platform adoption.

Heads of infrastructure and operations (I&O) are under pressure to mature their function to meet the increased demand for technology capabilities from the CIO and other C-suite executives. According to the 2025 Gartner CIO and Technology Executive Survey, 43% of respondents indicated they would focus on transforming the IT function's operating model in 2025. ¹ I&O must play its part in increasing resilience, improving adaptability and driving efficiency when the enterprise has adopted a digital transformation strategy.

Increasing I&O maturity is challenging, as evidenced by the lack of significant improvement in maturity over the past decade, as shown by Gartner's IT Score for I&O data. For example, the average maturity in articulating customer needs was unchanged at 2.76 in 2021 and 2025. ² This is not due to a lack of care or effort on the part of heads of I&O, but instead is driven by factors such as the following:

- **The wide range of concerns** that must be addressed for lasting maturity improvement, such as the organizational structure, performance metrics, talent development, delivery models, tools and financials in use
- **The variety of responsibilities** that fall within I&O, such as maintaining on-premises infrastructure, facilitating many different types of work requests, managing cloud services (and their providers) and engineering the self-service infrastructure platforms that underpin digital product delivery
- **The volumes of data** that must be collected, analyzed and made available in useful ways to people and technology so that they can make timely decisions with high degrees of accuracy
- **The rapidity of changes to infrastructure** that must be managed with little to no margin for error
- **The increasing rate of demand** for new infrastructure capabilities, many of which require the use of third-party providers that have their own communication protocols, release schedules and other ways of working
- **The greater volatility of business customer demand**, which can quickly swamp systems with requests at one moment and starve them of work at the next moment

These challenges can overwhelm heads of I&O and prompt them to either pursue a single permanent transformation or strive to preserve the status quo as much as possible. Neither approach is workable in the long term, though:

- Single permanent transformations rarely succeed because of the amount of change imposed and the need to maintain existing levels of performance while doing so. These efforts tend to have common outcomes:
 - Critical performance failures in existing systems force the abandonment of the transformation
 - Staff resistance to imposed changes forces the abandonment of new investments due to the limited value they deliver to the organization
 - Net increase in overall complexity, technologies to master and systems to manage
- Preserving the status quo forces other stakeholders to seek alternate providers for new capabilities, sidelining the value of I&O as more value shifts away from existing systems to digital products and platforms

Use this strategic roadmap to make an incremental, intentional transition from a service-centric I&O function to a platform-centric one, minimizing the risk to existing operations and proactively easing future state management (see Figure 1).

Figure 1: Strategic Roadmap Overview for Platform-Centric I&O

Strategic Roadmap Overview for Platform-Centric I&O

Current State	Future State	
• I&O is largely able to deliver against historical operational expectations and maintain infrastructure performance levels • Infrastructure does not have the self-service capabilities that developers and product teams need to keep pace with customer demand • I&O staff face a dizzying range of requests with little to no stable guidance on how to set priorities on what to do next • Infrastructure is difficult to automate and program in pursuit of maximizing value through dynamic management • Technical debt and staffing level limitations make it difficult to do more than maintain the status quo	• I&O is the provider of choice for infrastructure platforms underpinning digital products • Intelligent infrastructure is the default across environments • I&O staff expertise is embedded into systems and workflows that business technologies can self-serve in support of the enterprise mission • I&O offerings combine the best of third-party capabilities and built systems tailored to the specific needs and challenges of the organization • Every staff member has clarity regarding what is expected of them, how they contribute to the success of the overall organization and which methods and tools to use in order to do so • The head of I&O is viewed as a business leader with strong technical acumen and a key member of the executive team.	Gap • Insufficient intelligence built into the infrastructure stack • Mismatched I&O operating model performance and organizational objectives • Inadequate enterprise context for timely and accurate I&O-related decision making Migration Plan • Prepare for effective oversight of infrastructure platforms • Establish practices and tools vital to managing infrastructure platforms • Design systems and environments for infrastructure platform success

Source: Gartner
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Future State

I&O delivers on the goal of being the infrastructure provider of choice for the enterprise by making it easy for product teams to deliver value from digital products. Infrastructure platforms provide the capabilities and self-service that digital product teams need to deliver maximum value directly to external customers. Those platforms are composed of intelligent infrastructure deployed everywhere – on-premises, in remote business locations at the edge, colocation facilities and in the cloud. I&O staff spend more time embedding their expertise into infrastructure platforms than they do manually delivering I&O services, executing operational workflows and maintaining infrastructure assets.

The I&O operating model is focused on increasing the value that infrastructure platforms provide to external customers and making them more appealing to internal staff than alternatives from third parties. I&O uses and extends quality offerings from third parties when they meet business needs and builds its own offerings where market gaps exist. The head of I&O leads continuous efforts to create conditions where every hybrid infrastructure asset is fit for purpose, every I&O project and process delivers its intended outputs, every I&O service meets its agreed-upon service levels and every I&O platform provides the desired mission benefits. This increases I&O customer satisfaction and strengthens organizational performance while reducing the resources and time required to do so.

Heads of I&O lead an organization that provides clarity and focus to every staff member regarding their assignments, what is expected of them and how performance will be evaluated. A variety of roles exist, with some focused on platform engineering, others on service delivery and still others on maintaining and improving the critical infrastructure and practices that underpin business activities. Ways of working, tools, data sources and workspaces are all tailored to the needs of each role, with structured methods for coordinating between individuals and groups to minimize the need for inefficient meetings and waiting for critical resources.

The effectiveness and efficiency of I&O make it a core driver of the digital product strategy, as well as a crucial contributor to the exploration of autonomous business. The head of I&O is viewed as a business leader with strong technical acumen and is considered a key member of the executive leadership team.

Current State

Many heads of I&O have reached an equilibrium where they can maintain infrastructure performance levels and meet their historical operational expectations. However, this often masks issues, such as the following, that pose problems for I&O:

- Infrastructure does not have the self-service capabilities that developers and product teams need to keep pace with customer demand.
- I&O staff face a dizzying range of requests, alerts and needs all vying for their attention, with little to no stable guidance on how to prioritize this work across the different areas they are asked to support.
- I&O services often lack clear service-level agreements and defined outcomes, so they fail to deliver sufficient benefits for the costs incurred.

- Systems may be used past their end of life without appropriate risk mitigation, often due to gaps in accountability, life cycle planning and the inventory of I&O-owned assets.
- I&O projects fail to deliver intended benefits on time and on budget, undermining the return on investment for these efforts.
- ITSM processes are sometimes too slow, too failure prone and too opaque for requesters to have confidence that they will get what they need, when they need it.

The rapid adoption of technologies such as generative AI and AI agents is shattering this equilibrium. These technologies require infrastructure platforms to achieve their full value, as they cannot be managed at scale using traditional methods. This means that I&O functions plagued by the above issues will not be able to deliver the performance levels required for AI-dependent business strategies to succeed.

While many heads of I&O recognize the urgency of addressing this need, long-running challenges with technical debt accumulation and a lack of people continue to hamper their ability to respond effectively. In fact, these two challenges were the most frequently cited in the top three challenges both now and the next 12 months by respondents to the 2025 Gartner I&O Signature Role Survey.³ These limitations make it difficult to do more than maintain the status quo, which is increasing the risk that I&O functions will be sidelined as AI adoption rises. They are unable to meet new expectations necessary for business success.

Gap Analysis and Interdependencies

Making I&O platform-centric requires the remediation of three primary gaps:

- **Insufficient intelligence built into the infrastructure stack:** Digital products require an adaptive and resilient IT infrastructure to enable the ability to quickly respond to changing external demands with minimal waste and risk. These expectations cannot be met by people alone. Instead, I&O must require infrastructure assets to be interoperable, enabling the automation of routine work and programmatic delivery of infrastructure services, as these all play a critical role in infrastructure platform performance.

- **Mismatched I&O operating model performance and organizational objectives:**
Digital transformation and adoption of a digital product strategy requires an I&O operating model that makes it easy for product teams and business technologists to acquire and operate the IT infrastructure they need, when and where they need it. At the same time, the operating model must make it easy to measure and optimize I&O's contribution to the enterprise mission. When these desires are thwarted due to factors such as stagnant ways of working, unclear metrics and siloed team structures, it undermines the credibility that heads of I&O need to attract the necessary resources and support required for I&O to fulfill enterprise strategic needs that no one else can. The I&O operating model must be set up in a way that makes it easy to do things right and to focus improvements where they are most necessary.
- **Inadequate enterprise context for timely and accurate I&O-related decision making:**
As IT becomes more integral to business success, the ramifications of system outages, IT change failures and chronic technology problems become mission critical. I&O stakeholders require observability into critical systems so that high-stakes decisions can be made quickly and accurately. Untrustworthy data about systems, dependencies and performance against expectations forces the enterprise to take unacceptable risks or slow down responsiveness. Heads of I&O must ensure that there is accessible, high-quality information that enables traceability from business capabilities all the way to the infrastructure that supports them.

Heads of I&O cannot fix these gaps on their own. Adoption of platform-centric I&O requires the enterprise to adopt a digital transformation strategy focused on digital products as the primary means of serving customer needs. This strategy must provide the resources and support required to make I&O more capable of focusing on external customer needs and more proficient in managing infrastructure platforms at scale.

Migration Plan

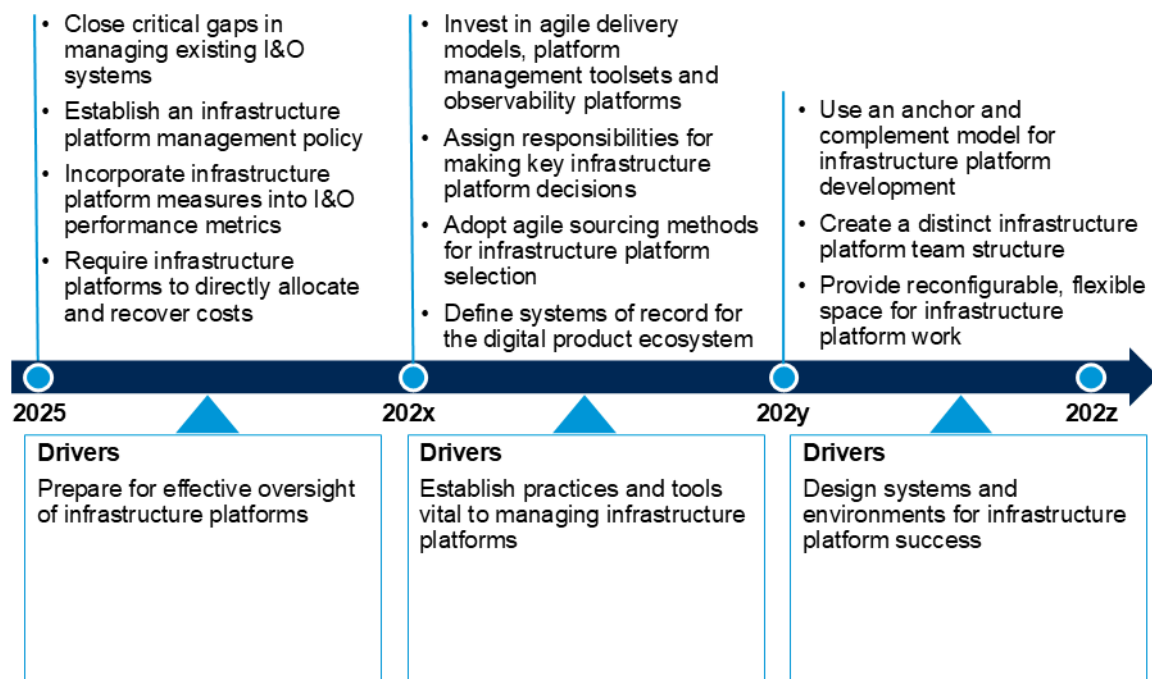
Infrastructure platforms play a critical role not only in delivering digital products but also in enabling the effective use of AI to support digital transformation. With the increased ease of obtaining and using third-party infrastructure platforms, heads of I&O must be able to outcompete these alternatives. This requires I&O to have both strong technical acumen and business acumen. With that in place, I&O can embrace and extend external offerings with differentiated capabilities that are highly appealing to senior executives and their digital product teams. If I&O cannot do this, it risks being sidelined into a purely tactical role — a maintainer of traditional systems that is only used when necessary and then is set aside when better alternatives emerge.

Heads of I&O cannot rely on mandates to drive infrastructure platform adoption. They must instead outperform alternatives in ways that truly matter to I&O's customers.

Shifting I&O's primary value focus from services to platforms requires focus and patience to refine all aspects of its operating model, infrastructure systems and the organizational data it manages. Heads of I&O must focus improvement efforts on critical items in each of these areas that will prevent infrastructure platforms from delivering business value. The strategic roadmap timeline in Figure 2 highlights key milestones in this work that are further discussed below.

Figure 2: Strategic Roadmap Timeline for Platform-Centric I&O

Strategic Roadmap Timeline for Platform-Centric I&O



Timeline indicates when to begin. Medium and long-term priority actions could commence in months or quarters, not necessarily the next year.

Source: Gartner
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Short Term Priority

Prepare for the Effective Oversight of Infrastructure Platforms

- **Close critical gaps in managing existing I&O systems** that will prevent success with infrastructure platform adoption. Issues with managing infrastructure asset masterlife cycles, making continuous improvements to I&O workflows, and overseeing the supply chain of I&O services will limit the resilience and adaptability of infrastructure platforms and prevent their enablement of self-service capabilities that digital product teams require (consult the resources in the Strategic Roadmap Toolkit included in this research for detailed lists and additional resources to aid this work).
- **Establish an infrastructure platform management policy** that provides clear guidance on when they will be established and how they will be governed (consult [Toolkit: Policies and Cultural Guidelines for Platform-Centric I&O](#) for a template to aid in developing this policy, as well as additional tools to help with governance and cultural readiness for infrastructure platforms).
- **Incorporate infrastructure platform measures into I&O performance metrics** that account for the direct business value being enabled by infrastructure platforms, the level of understanding of digital product stakeholder needs and their satisfaction with infrastructure platform offerings, and I&O readiness to adapt infrastructure platforms in response to the evolution of digital products (consult [Metrics for Managing Performance in Platform-Centric I&O](#) for a list of metrics useful for this purpose and for guidance on how to best make use of them).
- **Require infrastructure platforms to directly allocate and recover costs** from the digital products that consume them (consult [Update Cost Allocation Models for Effective Platform-Centric I&O](#) for details on how to structure this approach and what to do with existing cost allocation methods for other I&O offerings).

Medium Term Priority

Establish Practices and Tools Vital to Managing Infrastructure Platforms

- **Invest in agile delivery models, platform management toolsets and observability platforms** that provide infrastructure platform teams with the ways of working and technologies required to plan, implement, operate and monitor each platform (consult [The Essential Delivery Models and IT Tools for Platform-Centric I&O](#) for specific delivery models and technologies to consider and additional resources to aid in selection and implementation).

- **Assign responsibilities for making key infrastructure platform decisions** to provide clarity to all stakeholders on how decisions will be made and who will be involved in making them and carrying them out (consult [Tool: RACI Matrix for Platform-Centric I&O](#) for a template that can be used to speed allocation and documentation of responsibilities, as well as other critical I&O decisions to review and update).
- **Adopt agile sourcing methods for infrastructure platform selection** that make it easier for innovative vendors to participate in sourcing efforts while appropriately managing risks and reducing delays and costs that limit return on investment (consult [The Sourcing Essentials Crucial to Platform-Centric I&O](#) for an overview of Gartner's Dynamic Sourcing approach and how it can be used to guide this work).
- **Define systems of record for the digital product ecosystem** that provide a coherent, consistent view of infrastructure platforms, the digital products they enable and the business customers that the enterprise mission supports (consult [The System Data You Must Get Right for Platform-Centric I&O](#) for guidance on information to include, along with guidance on where to focus observability efforts and how to ensure data completeness and quality meet I&O's needs).

Long Term Priority

Design Systems and Environments for Infrastructure Platform Success

- **Use an anchor and complement model for infrastructure platform development** to reduce complexity and limit duplicate spending on vital capabilities (consult [The Infrastructure You Need for Platform-Centric I&O](#) for specific infrastructure technology to consider as anchors, along with complementary technologies to consider and guidance on what to do with existing systems).
- **Create a distinct infrastructure platform team structure** that provides the flexibility for each infrastructure platform team to organize as it best sees fit to meet digital product needs (consult [Toolkit: Organizational Structure and Roles for Platform-Centric I&O](#) for tools to aid the updating of I&O's organizational structure to accommodate infrastructure platform teams and help them work well with other I&O teams).
- **Provide reconfigurable, flexible space for infrastructure platform work** that makes it easy for teams to connect with the information they need, team members and other collaborators such as digital product teams and external platform providers (consult [Tool: Workplace Planning Checklist for Platform-Centric I&O](#) for specific considerations to account for in workplace setup for infrastructure platform teams as well as other I&O teams and systems).

Create mechanisms in each of these areas to regularly review outcomes and make adjustments to improve performance. This ability to learn and adapt is the key to achieving sustained success with platform-centric I&O.

Strategic Roadmap Toolkit

Table 1: Strategic Roadmap Tools for Platform-Centric I&O Planning

Tool	Description
Strategic roadmap template	This template can be used to create a tailored strategic roadmap for platform-centric I&O. It also includes additional migration activity candidates that include descriptions, recommended actions and additional Gartner resources to aid planning and execution.
Strategic roadmap overview	This configurable graphic can be used to create a tailored overview of the desired future state for platform-centric I&O, the current state, key gaps and interdependencies, and a summary of key steps in the migration plan.
Strategic roadmap timeline	This configurable graphic can be used to create a tailored timeline of key milestones toward putting platform-centric I&O into place.

Source: Gartner (December 2025)

When to Use

Use this Toolkit to create a tailored document that can be used to garner support for positioning I&O as a platform-centric function that can meet all of the organization's needs for infrastructure and operational support to enable its digital product strategy. It provides prompts to help educate key stakeholders on the current situation and the benefits and risks of this work in business terms; create a sequence of actions that maximizes the odds of success; and obtain the resources and sponsorship required to carry them out.

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Evidence

¹ **2025 Gartner CIO and Technology Executive Survey.** This survey tracked how senior IT leaders worldwide prioritize strategic business, technical and management objectives. It was conducted online from 1 May through 28 June 2024. The survey includes respondents who lead an IT function, with a total of 3,186 CIOs and technology executives participating. The survey participants are representative of various geographies, revenue bands and industry sectors, including both public and private organizations. Disclaimer: The results of the survey do not represent global findings or the market as a whole, but reflect the sentiments of the respondents and companies surveyed.

² **The IT Score for Infrastructure and IT Operations** offers the best of Gartner expertise and peer-based research. Maturity is measured on a scale ranging from 1 (low) to 5 (high). It measures how advanced an organization's development is in a functional activity relative to Gartner's expert assessment of practices associated with that activity. The maturity of an activity is measured by several subactivities weighted 1 through 5, depending on how progressive they are. Importance is measured on a scale of 1 (low) to 5 (high). Importance measures how important each functional activity is to the overall effectiveness of the function in meeting its business objectives. 341 organizations completed the IT Score for Infrastructure & IT Operations assessment online from September 2024 through June 2025. Longer-term analysis of IT Score for I&O performance based on average maturity observed in analysis of additional data and surveys from 2021 and from 2013 as noted in "Use 3 Key Findings From I&O IT Score Assessment Data to Drive Business Growth" and "Survey Analysis: IT Score for I&O Survey Results Show No Improvement."

³ **2025 Gartner I&O Signature Role Survey.** This survey was conducted to identify the key goals and challenges faced by infrastructure and operations leaders. Additionally, the study focuses on understanding key aspects related to technical debt, the primary drivers of investment decisions, and the adoption of AI within the infrastructure and operations (I&O) function. The research was conducted online from May through July 2025 among 253 respondents from the United States (n = 119), the United Kingdom (n=52), India (n=51) and Germany (n=31). Qualifying organizations operated in multiple industries and reported enterprisewide revenue for fiscal year 2024 of at least \$50 million or equivalent. Qualified respondents were screened to be heads of I&O or CIOs. All respondents led, participated in or influenced strategies and investment decisions for infrastructure and operations. Disclaimer: The results of this study do not represent global findings or the market as a whole, but reflect the sentiments of the respondents and companies surveyed.

Recommended by the Author

Some documents may not be available as part of your current Gartner subscription.

[Use the Value-Optimizing IT Operating Model to Advance Digital Transformation](#)

[Leverage the Pareto Principle to Rapidly Target High-Impact Improvements in I&O](#)

[Top Practices for I&O Leaders to Form and Operate Platform Teams](#)

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